younger England players: they were excited about the build-up, the new suits, the uniform, the attention and everything. But as far as the soccer was concerned, the World Cup for them just meant more big games to look forward to. They weren't scared of anything and that kept them very relaxed. It was the likes of me and Michael Owen, Gareth Southgate, Martin Keown and Dave Seaman who'd been there before and understood just how big a World Cup was and how much was at stake for us all.

The week in Dubai gave the players some time to rest after a season at home that had only just finished. It didn't seem long before I was saying goodbye to Victoria and Brooklyn and traveling east with the squad. There was going to be so much traveling during the World Cup itself that we decided it would be too much for our families. We were going to be based in Japan for the tournament but we stopped off in South Korea for the first of two warm-up exhibitions. We checked into our hotel and you could see the change of mood on the players' faces. We were here now. This was where the World Cup was going to take place. That first match was a good jolt for us, as we only drew 1–1 with the Koreans in Seogwipo. We experimented with a few things and nobody was at it full throttle, but it was obvious South Korea could play; and they were incredibly fit. Which was more than could be said for me. I wasn't even close, eleven days before our first official game.

Sven had taken on this Dutchman, Richard Smith, as one of four masseurs who traveled with the squad to Japan. Somebody stuck up a card on Richard's door that read 'HOUSE OF PAIN'. They weren't far wrong. Richard would work deep, deep into where your injury was. I can't describe what it felt like. It just made your guts turn over it hurt so much. But it worked. Thanks to Richard I got there in the end and, later, Michael Owen made the Brazil game because of him working on his groin injury the day before.

Our other exhibition was in Japan against Cameroon the following Sunday. Although I couldn't play, the medical team thought I needed the boost of being involved with the rest of the lads so I led the team out for the warm-up. It was a decent game to watch despite the players holding back in their tackles, for obvious reasons, and the final score was 2–2. That afternoon, I found myself thinking back to my lowest point in the whole rehabilitation process. Quite soon after the injury happened, England had an exhibition against Paraguay. The squad met up at a hotel and Sven invited me along. He wanted me to be part of our build-up because he believed all along I was going to play in Japan. I got there for dinner and it was good to see all the other lads but, at that stage, I was still on crutches most of the time. The next morning, when the squad went off to train, I found myself sitting on my own